

Chapter

The Guru's Tears — The Hidden Truth of Rudra and Rudraksha



Introduction: One Bead, a Deep Symbol

The rudraksha is held in great reverence in our tradition. The Shiva Purana devotes an entire section to it, and people wear it with devotion. Acharya Ji begins right here:

"Rudraksha — there is a special segment about it in the **Charitramrit**. In the Shiva Purana there would be a whole segment on it; a complete section on rudraksha comes there."

But in this discourse Acharya Ji does not speak about the outer or scientific use of the rudraksha. He opens up its symbolic meaning at the level of Vedanta:

"I am giving a definition entirely at the level of Vedanta. I am not teaching some general dictionary meaning, not a word-to-word translation — I am telling you the deep symbolic meaning."

To understand it, we must first understand the word "Rudra".

Not Raudra, but Rudra

Most people associate "Rudra" with anger. Acharya Ji first removes exactly this confusion:

"**Raudra** is different — the **raudra** form means that utterly wrathful form. That is not what Rudra means."

He explains that Rudra, Vasu and Aditya are names of classes of deities counted among the "33 koti" gods. Once the

meaning of these three is understood, the meaning of Rudra becomes clear by itself.

Aditya and Vasu: Those Who Stay With Us, Those Through Whom We Live

The **Adityas** are twelve — like the twelve months that go along with us all year:

"Twelve Adityas means twelve months. Basically, a person who thinks for you all the time, walks with you, lives only for you — that is called Aditya."

"Aditya means the one who is with me twenty-four hours, with me twelve months, who works for me, stays with me, lives for me."

The **Vasus** are those because of whom our dwelling and our life are possible (from **vāsa**, dwelling):

"Vasu means that in which we can live, where dwelling is possible. So the earth will be a Vasu; because of the sun we can live, so the sun will be a Vasu. So many such things by which we can survive, by which we can sustain, by which our life can be — that is called Vasu."

And of such people Acharya Ji says:

"Such people are like God."

Rudra: The One Whose Absence Makes You Cry

Now the third — Rudra. The word is connected with **rudana** (crying), but its meaning is not simply crying:

"Rudra basically means **rudana**, crying. But not crying as such — the one in whose absence you are brought to tears, that is Rudra. Meaning, while it is there, its importance is nothing at all."

Acharya Ji explains this with the most ordinary example — your own fingernail:

"Even one of your fingernails — these nails — doesn't feel important; we don't realise it. If by mistake it breaks, snaps right down to here, and it burns like fire, there will be pain, won't there? Then you could be brought to tears."

And the organs inside the body, which keep working silently day and night:

"When was the last time you thought about your lungs? Tell me — that they are working, and that is why I can live. When was the last time you thought about your heart — 'Oh, the poor thing is pumping'?"

"When was the last time you thought about your spleen, your gall bladder — when did you think about all this? But if by any mistake something goes wrong in even one of them, a problem, you could be brought to tears, couldn't you? All such things are called Rudra."

The "God of Cricket" — An Example of Rudra

Another example from everyday life, one many people will recognise from their own experience:

"At one time our cricket team had only one God of Cricket, you know? As long as he was there, there was enjoyment, and the moment he was out, the whole team — the match would stop in the middle. You know, 1990 — I am talking about Sachin Tendulkar."

"As long as it is there, it feels like it is just ours; you don't even bother. But if it goes out of your life, or its use, its function stops even slightly, it will bring you to the condition of crying."

Rudras are within us too — **the five organs of action, the five organs of perception, and the mind**, eleven in all:

"Rudra is also inside you — the five **karmendriyas** and five **jñānendriyas**, the sensory and motor organs, and one mind, are called Rudra. Why? If these too go wrong, the same crying will come."

"Rudra also means anything that makes you cry due to its absence. Not from its presence."

Here Acharya Ji clears up the distinction with a light touch:

"If you want to cry because of presence, you may marry — that is enough! Someone, a spouse, has arrived in front of you, and then trouble — that is different. Crying from absence — from absence."

Rudraksha: Shiva's Tears, That Is, the Guru's Tears

Now the second part of the word — **akṣa**, the eye, the tear of the eye. The popular story is that rudraksha beads arose from Shiva's tears. Acharya Ji goes beyond that story to its inner meaning:

"'Rudra' means Lord Shiva, and 'akṣa' of course is the tear of the eyes; it is basically tears. So 'Shiva's tears fell and from them the rudraksha arose' — all that is imaginary, all of it. It actually means — the Guru is Shiva, Shiva is the Guru. So it is about that Guru."

Shiva is the Guru, the Guru is Shiva — this is the axis of the entire discourse.

The Guru Too Is Rudra — The Secret of the Guru's Grace

The Guru also falls within the definition of Rudra, because whatever is going well in life is going well by his grace — and we realise this only when that grace is no longer there:

"As long as the Guru is in one's life, while the Guru's grace is flowing, when everything of mine is going fine — that too happens by the Guru's grace. Even for an atheist, whatever is going fine is going on because of some Guru's grace from a previous birth."

As evidence, Acharya Ji refers to the ninth chapter of the Bhagavad Gita (verses 20–21), where Lord Krishna explains that one who enjoys heaven by the strength of merit returns to the mortal world as soon as that merit is exhausted:

**te taṁ bhuktvā svarga-lokaṁ viśālaṁ
kṣīṇe puṇye martya-lokaṁ viśanti**

"Having enjoyed that vast heavenly world, when
their merit is exhausted, they enter the mortal
world."

— Bhagavad Gita 9.21

"When Lord Krishna says clear-cut that he experiences the vast heaven through past merit — and past merit has come about through some Guru's grace — that is what the Bhagavad Gita says. As soon as it is exhausted — '**kṣīṇe puṇye martya-lokaṁ viśanti**' — then the time for crying will come. So the Guru also will qualify — as what, then? As Rudra, no?"

Why Does the Guru Weep?

So rudraksha means the Guru's tears. But the question arises — why would one who is beyond pleasure and pain shed tears?

"Do you know when the Guru will shed tears? When will the Guru cry? What pleasure and pain do they have? But they are human. But why will they cry? When they see the world does not follow Vedanta correctly — which is what is happening now."

yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati bhārata

"O Bharata, whenever there is a decline of dharma."

— Bhagavad Gita 4.7

"When that decline is seen happening, when everyone is seen making a mess, when all that adharma grows — that time the Guru feels bad."

The Last Hope: The Parable of the Gravely Ill Patient

Acharya Ji explains this pain of the Guru, and along with it the Guru's unbreakable hope, through a parable. (He makes clear it is only an example — "May no one have this; do Shiva sadhana, Rudra sadhana, and it won't happen at all.")

"If someone has cancer, then even if 80% of the cells in the body have gone bad, last stage, everything, it has reached multiple organ failure — even then, has a single person ever said, 'Oh, anyway it's 80% damage, all 100% is going to go, so I'll just die'?"

"He still goes to the doctor as a last hope, that this 80% will still get better. He may be crying, but doesn't he feel that there is a chance, it can still happen? So why does he feel this? Because it is my own body, and I want to live."

Now apply the same to the Guru. The Guru's "self" has become so vast that the entire world is his body — in the words of the Gita, "**vāsudevaḥ sarvam iti**":

vāsudevaḥ sarvam iti sa mahātmā sudurlabhaḥ

"'Vasudeva is everything' — such a great soul is
very rare."

— Bhagavad Gita 7.19

"That Guru, whose self has itself become so big that it pervades as much as the world — '**vāsudevaḥ sarvam iti**' — when he has become like that, and now he sees a full 80% of people gone bad, sees corruption, sees negativity, sees everything — what do you think, wouldn't he too feel like crying, wouldn't he feel bad?"

"But he still is a person who does not lose hope — some cure is still possible. He sees something like death — the whole earth is going into a downfall in the Kali Yuga — still there must be some one chance. **The one who takes that chance is the Guru.**"

And how that chance is taken:

"He feels — 'Something has happened; I will do something, I will stop it, I will make a **sankalpa**, I will do sadhana, I will bring about some awakening, I will do **shaktipat**.' As a last remedy, a Guru feels this. Because his self itself is so big. When the self is the body, we try for it till the last moment."

Not an Outer Bead, but Inner Remembrance

So what does wearing the rudraksha mean? Acharya Ji says plainly that its scientific or worldly use is not under discussion here at all — that belongs to **Purva Mimamsa** (the ritual portion of the Vedas), whereas here the subject is **Uttara Mimamsa**, that is, Vedanta and knowledge:

"What its scientific use is — it is not the discussion at all. All that comes in Purva Mimamsa, all that comes in the part of the Vedas. We don't want a worldly-level explanation. What comes in Uttara Mimamsa, meaning Vedanta — what comes from knowledge?"

He gives his own example:

"I don't wear rudraksha — if I want, I wear it sometimes; if not, I won't wear it; it doesn't make a difference. After going to a certain level, beyond that you don't require anything."

And then the definition that is the essence of this chapter:

"So symbolically, wearing the rudraksha means remembering the Guru so much, every moment, that before doing any wrong action, I remember the Guru first — will tears come to his eyes?"

"I am going to eat something wrong, I went to a hotel, these are **tamasic** and **rajasic** foods — I should remember immediately."

The Third in Every Relationship: The Guru

Acharya Ji ties this remembrance into a beautiful principle — whatever object, person or place we deal with, the Guru should always be present between it and us:

"Between two things — one, you; and the other, some object or person, thing or place you are dealing with — between these there will always be a third thing, and that will be the Guru."

The same question in all of life's small decisions:

- Going to buy clothes — will the Guru like it?
- Going to eat a meal — will the Guru like it?
- Going on an outing to such a place — will the Guru be pleased?
- Taking a shortcut in worship — will the Guru like it?

"Every time when you start seeing this — 'my Guru will get tears', meaning unhappy about me — **the one in whose mind this feeling arises has truly worn the rudraksha; so says Vedanta.**"

From Veda to Vedanta: The Final Surrender

Acharya Ji reminds us that this is a class in Vedanta, not in the Vedas — and that the Gita's final teaching too is to leave

all outer dharmas and go to one refuge:

"The Vedas will say something else. A Veda class is not going on here; Veda classes will go on everywhere else, all over the world. Then what was said at the very end? Forget all this."

**sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇaṁ
vraja**

"Abandoning all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone."

— Bhagavad Gita 18.66

"What was told there — that is final."

And finally, the essence of the whole teaching:

"When the definition of Rudra was explained, the rudraksha explained — Shiva is the Guru, the Guru is Shiva; in the absence of the Guru, in the absence of the Guru's grace, one can be brought to tears — then wearing it means you should feel, 'With my every action, could this bring a fault against the Guru?' For this feeling to come... **as devotion to the Guru grows, the rudraksha is automatically worn.**"

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Rudra and Raudra are different.** Raudra is the wrathful form; Rudra is that whose absence makes you cry — whose importance we don't even notice while it is present.
- 2 Aditya, Vasu and Rudra** — Adityas are those who are always with us and live for us; Vasus are those through whom our life is possible (like the earth and the sun); Rudras are those whose absence brings us to tears.

- 3 The Rudras are within us too** — the five organs of action, the five organs of perception, and the mind; only when they fail do we understand their worth.
- 4 Shiva is the Guru, the Guru is Shiva.** The real meaning of the rudraksha — "Shiva's tears" — is the Guru's tears.
- 5 Whatever is going well in life is going well by the Guru's grace** — even in an atheist's life, through some Guru's grace from a previous birth. Its value is understood only when that merit is exhausted.
- 6 The Guru weeps when the world strays from Vedanta** — yet never gives up hope. One whose "self" has become the whole world tries to heal it till the last moment, through **sankalpa**, sadhana and **shaktipat**.
- 7 Wearing the rudraksha, symbolically, is remembering the Guru every moment** — asking before any action, "Will this bring tears to my Guru's eyes?"
- 8 Let the Guru be the third in every dealing** — food, clothing, travel, worship — keeping the Guru's pleasure in mind in every decision.

9 The outer bead is not essential — beyond a certain level no outer support is needed. As devotion to the Guru grows, the rudraksha is worn on its own.